

Topic 12: Multilingual Content with AI

12.1 AI Translation Capabilities

- Modern LLMs (Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini) translate accurately in 50+ languages with natural, idiomatic phrasing
- DeepL (deepl.com): specialised translation tool; widely regarded as producing the highest quality for European languages; free tier available
- Google Translate: broad language coverage, fast, good for informal use and getting the gist of a document
- For published or customer-facing content: always have a native speaker review AI translations
- Strength varies by language: AI performs best on widely-represented languages (Spanish, French, German, Mandarin, Japanese)

12.2 Localisation vs Translation

- Translation: converting the words of a text from one language to another
- Localisation: adapting content for cultural context -- idioms, units of measurement, date formats, cultural references, humour
- Prompt for localisation: 'Translate and localise this for a [country] audience. Adapt idioms and cultural references to be locally relevant.'
- Formal vs informal register: many languages (French, German, Spanish, Japanese) distinguish formal and informal 'you' -- specify which to use
- Right-to-left languages (Arabic, Hebrew, Urdu): AI handles the text content well; ensure your web platform renders RTL correctly

12.3 Multilingual Content Strategy

- Avoid simply translating your existing content -- each market may need different topics, examples, and tone
- AI can generate market-specific content from scratch with the right prompts and local knowledge input
- Prompt: 'Write a blog post about [topic] for a small business audience in [country]. Use locally relevant examples and regulations.'
- SEO: keyword research in the target language is separate from English keyword strategy -- provide local terms to the AI
- Consistency: AI can generate multilingual glossaries to maintain consistent terminology across all language versions

12.4 Quality Assurance for Translated Content

- Back-translation check: translate the AI output back to English to identify any meaning drift or errors
 - Native reviewer: essential for any customer-facing, published, or legally significant content
 - Tone review: formal business content and casual consumer content require different registers in each language
 - Legal and compliance content: AI may not know local regulatory requirements -- expert review is mandatory
 - Practical workflow: AI for first-draft translation (fast and cheap) + native speaker for review and polish (targeted cost)
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